

M2T5: Meal Planning Templates — 10 min

Video File M2T5-Planning.mp4 · **Resources** Meal Template.xlsx (weekly planner, fertility-plate builder, 3-day sample plan, shopping tab) · **Xp** 80 total · Plan 3 Meals 50 · Prep & Follow Plan 30

Target runtime 10 min · 1,257 spoken words · ≈ 8.4 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 9.3 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 **HOOK**

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera. B-roll: a couple standing in front of an open fridge at 6:40 p.m., both tired, both scrolling delivery apps.]

"What's for dinner?" Three words, asked at six-forty in the evening, by two tired people, have derailed more good intentions than any dessert ever has. Not because anyone lacks willpower, but because a decision made hungry and late is a decision made by your cravings. Today we take that decision away from six-forty and give it to Sunday afternoon, where it belongs.

0:30–2:30 **WHY PLANNING WORKS**

[VISUAL: Slide: "Meal planning: better diet quality, more variety, healthier weight." Citation: IJBNPA 2017.]

In a study of more than forty thousand adults published in the International Journal of Behavioral Nutrition and Physical Activity, people who planned their meals had higher diet quality, more food variety, and were less likely to be overweight than people who didn't, and they were also more

likely to cook at home. That's a big study saying something simple: the plan does part of the work for you.

Here's why it matters for fertility specifically. Every training in this module asks you to add something: greens at two meals, a protein-first breakfast, a fermented food, a fertility fat. None of that happens by accident at six-forty. It happens because on Sunday, when you were calm and fed, you decided Tuesday would be salmon and Wednesday would be lentils, and you bought the ingredients. Planning isn't rigidity. It's kindness to your future tired self.

Before the template, let me give you the simplest planning tool I know: the five-ingredient dinner. A protein, two vegetables, a slow carbohydrate, and a fat. Salmon, broccoli, sweet potato, pesto. Chicken, peppers, onions, brown rice, olive oil. Lentils, spinach, tomatoes, quinoa, tahini. Once you think in fives, you can plan a week in about ten minutes, and you can shop for it from a single list. Every plan in the template is built this way.

And there's the craving connection. Remember the physiological bucket from Module One: skipped meals and

low-protein lunches schedule the evening craving. A plan is the most reliable way I know to make sure every meal has the protein, fat, and fiber that keep blood sugar steady.

2:30–7:30 WALKTHROUGH: THE FERTILITY PLATE AND A THREE-DAY PLAN

[VISUAL: The fertility plate graphic: half the plate vegetables and fruit, a quarter protein, a quarter slow carbohydrate, with a drizzle of healthy fat.]

Let's start with the shape of a meal. I use what I call the fertility plate, adapted from Harvard's Healthy Eating Plate. Half the plate is vegetables, with a little fruit, as many colors as you can manage. A quarter is protein: fish, eggs, poultry, beans, lentils, tofu, or full-fat dairy. A quarter is slow carbohydrate: oats, quinoa, brown rice, sweet potato, whole-grain bread, or beans doing double duty. And a drizzle of healthy fat over the whole thing: olive oil, avocado, nuts, seeds. If a meal has those four things, blood sugar stays steady and the fertility nutrients we listed in Training One arrive on their own.

[DEMO: Cynthia opens the Meal Template spreadsheet on screen and fills in a three-day plan as she talks.]

Now let's build three days together in the template. Day one. Breakfast: the Baby Steps smoothie from Training One. Lunch: a big salad with leafy greens, a can of sardines or a

hard-boiled egg, chickpeas, olive oil, and a tablespoon of sauerkraut on the side for your gut. Dinner: baked salmon, roasted broccoli and sweet potato, and a spoon of pesto.

Day two. Breakfast: two eggs scrambled with spinach, avocado on the side, a slice of whole-grain toast if you want it. Lunch: leftover salmon flaked into a grain bowl with quinoa and whatever vegetables are left. Dinner: a lentil and vegetable soup, made in one pot, with plain yogurt stirred in at the table.

Day three. Breakfast: plain whole-milk Greek yogurt with berries, walnuts, and ground flax. Lunch: leftover lentil soup. Dinner: a stir-fry of chicken or tofu with lots of vegetables, ginger, and garlic over brown rice, and kimchi on the side.

[VISUAL: The template fills in; a shopping tab auto-lists the ingredients.]

Notice the pattern. Nothing is cooked from scratch twice. Salmon becomes lunch. Soup becomes lunch. Breakfast rotates between three options, and that's not boring; that's freedom, because you never have to think about breakfast again. The template has a shopping tab that builds your list

from what you typed, and a "double it" column for batch cooking.

Batch cooking is the other half of the plan. Sunday afternoon, two hours: roast a tray of vegetables, cook a pot of grains, make the soup, boil six eggs, wash and dry the greens. On Tuesday night, dinner is assembly, not cooking, and assembly takes ten minutes. If Sunday isn't your day, pick any two hours. The point is that the future tired you is being cared for by the present rested you.

Your freezer is your quiet partner in all of this. Soup freezes in single portions. Cooked grains freeze flat in bags. Roasted vegetables freeze well enough for a weeknight stir-fry. A bag of frozen wild salmon portions is dinner insurance. Label everything with the date, use it within about three months, and cool cooked food before it goes in. A stocked freezer means a bad day never has to become a bad dinner.

7:30–9:00 CUSTOMIZATION: PARTNERS, BUDGETS, REAL LIFE

[VISUAL: Slide: "Make it yours: partner · budget · culture · time."]

Now let's customize, because a plan you can't live with is just a list of things to feel bad about.

Partners. If one of you needs more food than the other, don't cook two dinners; cook one and change the portions. The bigger plate gets extra protein and grain. If one partner is more enthusiastic than the other, let the less enthusiastic one pick one dinner a week, no questions asked. Ownership beats compliance, every time.

Budget. Fertility eating does not require salmon every night. Eggs, canned sardines, frozen vegetables, dried lentils, oats, seasonal produce, and frozen berries are some of the cheapest foods in the store and some of the best on our list. The Grocery List spreadsheet has a budget column for exactly this reason. Buy what's in season; it's cheaper and it tastes better.

Culture and taste. This plate works with any cuisine. Dal and rice with a vegetable curry is a fertility plate. Beans, rice, and a big salsa is a fertility plate. Miso soup, rice, fish, and pickled vegetables is a fertility plate with a fermented food built in. Please don't abandon the foods you love for a plan you don't. Keep the flavors; adjust the proportions.

Time. If two hours of batch cooking sounds impossible, start with one thing: boil six eggs on Sunday. That alone fixes

breakfast for three days. Next week, add the soup. Baby steps apply in the kitchen too.

And for the day that explodes, the sick child, the late meeting, the flat tire, keep an emergency dinner list on the fridge: three meals you can make in ten minutes from things that keep. Eggs scrambled with frozen spinach and a side of yogurt. Canned sardines or beans on whole-grain toast with a bag of salad. A frozen salmon portion in the oven with a bag of frozen vegetables and microwaved brown rice. None of these is a compromise; each one is a fertility plate. The template has a tab for your emergency list, and I'd fill it in before you need it.

9:00–9:40 HEART-LED CLOSE

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]

I want to say something to the person who feels a little overwhelmed right now. You don't have to become a meal-prep influencer. You have to make Tuesday easier than it was last week. That's it. A plan that is seventy percent followed is a hundred percent better than a perfect plan that lives in a drawer. And every planned meal is one fewer decision made

by your cravings, and one more meal that quietly feeds the family you're preparing for.

9:40–10:00 ACTION HANDOFF

[VISUAL: End card: "Meal Template XLS → Plan 3 meals (50 XP) → Prep and follow the plan (30 XP)."]

Open the Meal Template spreadsheet and plan three meals for fifty XP. Prep them and follow the plan for thirty. Then meet me in Training Six, where we talk about food sensitivities, and the one test you should never skip.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Meal Template.xlsx (weekly planner, fertility-plate builder, 3-day sample plan, auto-shopping tab, batch-cook checklist). **ACTION 1:** Plan 3 meals in the template (50 XP). **ACTION 2:** Prep and follow the plan (30 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 6 · Food Sensitivities and Elimination.